

while working on worksheets or while watching a movie.

Oddly enough, the Toshiba Satellite had a 'mirror finish' to its monitor, which took away much of the detail while viewing anything in a properly lit room. The MSI MegaBook sported the

only grow, as the popularity of Gigabit is fast increasing. Gigabit allows ten times faster data transfers over a LAN.

To be able to make presentations while on the road, D-Sub and S-video connectors are important. These can also be used to output video onto bigger televisions at home in order to watch movies, play a game or run a slideshow of your personal photographs.

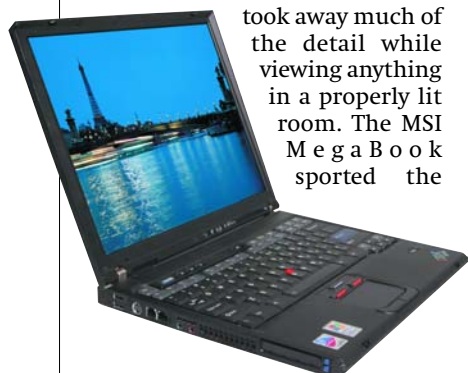
When it comes to data storage, anything above 20 GB is decent for a laptop, and all the laptops we tested had at least this much to offer. The MSI MegaBook M510C came with an 80 GB drive.

The integrated graphics chip present in most of the laptops is good enough for common usage. However, some laptops do offer the option of a dedicated card. If you are looking to do design work on your workhorse, such as CAD/CAM, consider such a solution. Some Thinkpads, for example, offer the option of workstation-class graphics cards with 128 MB of onboard memory.

The IBM T42 had an ATi Radeon 7500 with 32 MB of dedicated DDR RAM; the Acer and the MSI came with an ATi Radeon 9700 with 64 MB of dedicated DDR RAM, whereas the Toshiba came with an nVidia GeForce Go 5200 with 64 MB of dedicated DDR RAM.

All the laptops in this category came equipped with an optical combo drive capable of burning CD-ROMs. This is a handy feature, suited for taking backups on either archival CDs or on rewritable CD-RWs. The Fujitsu and the IBM T42 also featured biometric fingerprint scanners for added security. These allow biometric access to password-protected data within e-mail boxes, instant messengers and VPNs.

Usability: The Fujitsu LifeBook S7010 had the smallest dimensions and was the lightest. In fact, it



IBM Thinkpad T42

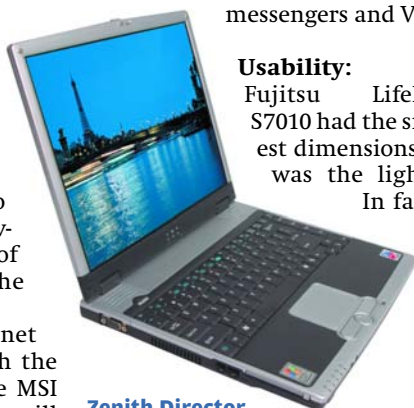
highest native resolution of 1,400 x 1,050. When it comes to connectivity, serial and parallel ports, while still important, are sidelined by the now-ubiquitous USB ports. A few models, from vendors such as MSI, came with a parallel and a serial port. The Zenith Director had four USB ports, which was the highest, three or two being the norm.

FireWire is also gaining in presence, and all laptops except for the IBM Thinkpad T42 came with a FireWire port. This provides a fast interface for connecting digital imaging equipment such as DV cams to a laptop.

An infra-red (IrDA) port, though old, was still present on almost every laptop except for the Zenith and the Toshiba. IR ports, slow as they may be, are a very useful feature for exchanging data with handhelds such as cell phones and PDAs. IrDA allows for synching of your Outlook address book, notes, to-dos, images and so on. The models from Acer and BenQ also supported the faster and more convenient Bluetooth.

As wireless networks increase in popularity within offices, and as Wi-Fi hotspots trickle into our country, Wi-Fi-enabled laptops make for a worthwhile investment. Most of these are based on Intel's Centrino platform. Wi-Fi connectivity was indeed part of every laptop, save for the Zenith Director.

Faster Gigabit Ethernet ports were provided with the Fujitsu, the IBM and the MSI laptops, and this number will



Zenith Director

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